

{3} Current Electricity

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INTRODUCTION

- * In the previous two chapters, all charges whether free or bound, were considered to be at rest.
- * **Charges in motion constitute an electric current.**
- * In the present chapter, we shall study some of the basic laws concerning **steady electric currents**.

ELECTRIC CURRENT

- * The electric current through any cross-section area is defined as the net charge (ΔQ) flowing through the area per unit time.

$$I_{\text{avg.}} = \frac{\Delta Q}{\Delta t} \quad \text{..... (average current)}$$

- * **Instantaneous Current $I(t)$:** The current at time t across the cross-section of the conductor is defined as the value of the ratio of ΔQ to Δt in the limit of Δt tending to zero,

$$I(t) = \lim_{\Delta t \rightarrow 0} \frac{\Delta Q}{\Delta t} = \frac{dQ}{dt} \quad \text{.... instantaneous current}$$

- * SI unit of electric current is ampere (A).

$$1 \text{ A} = \frac{1 \text{ C}}{1 \text{ s}}$$

- * The direction of current is taken as the direction of motion +ve charges or opposite to the motion of -ve charge.

Ex 1 : In cosmic rays 0.15 protons/cm²-s are entering the earth's atmosphere. If the radius of the earth is 6400 km, what is the current received by the earth in the form of cosmic rays?

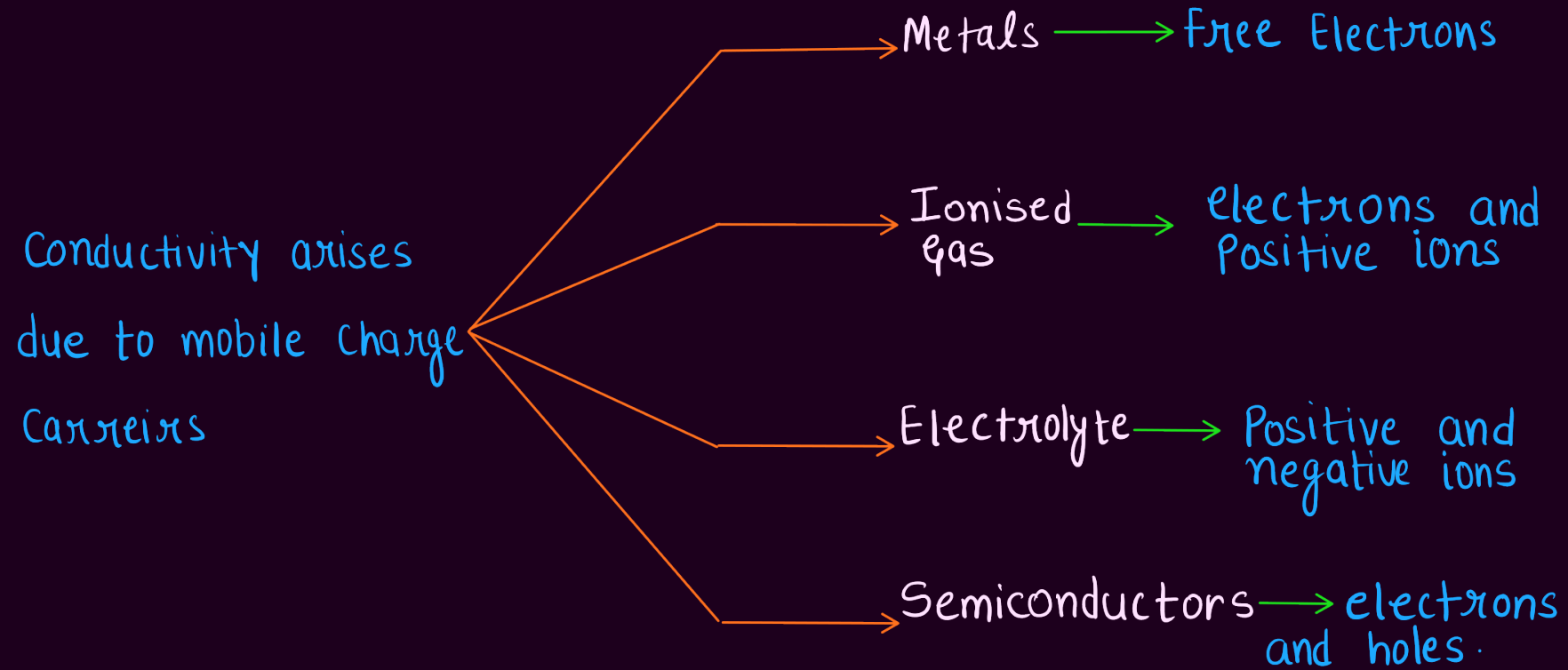
Ex 2: In neon gas discharge tube 2.9×10^{18} Ne^+ ions move to the right through a cross-section of the tube each second, while 1.2×10^{18} electrons move to the left in this time. What is the net electric current in the tube?

Ex 3 : In the Bohr's model of hydrogen atom, the electron is assumed to rotate in a circular orbit of radius 5×10^{-11} m, at a speed of 2.2×10^6 m/s. What is the current associated with electron motion?

Ex 4 : The current in a wire varies with time according to the relation $I = 2 \text{ A} + (0.6 \text{ A/s}^2) t^2$.

- (a) How many coulomb of charge pass a cross-section of the wire in the time interval between $t = 0$ and $t = 10 \text{ s}$?
- (b) What constant current would transport the same charge in same charge in the same time interval?

ELECTRIC CURRENTS IN CONDUCTORS



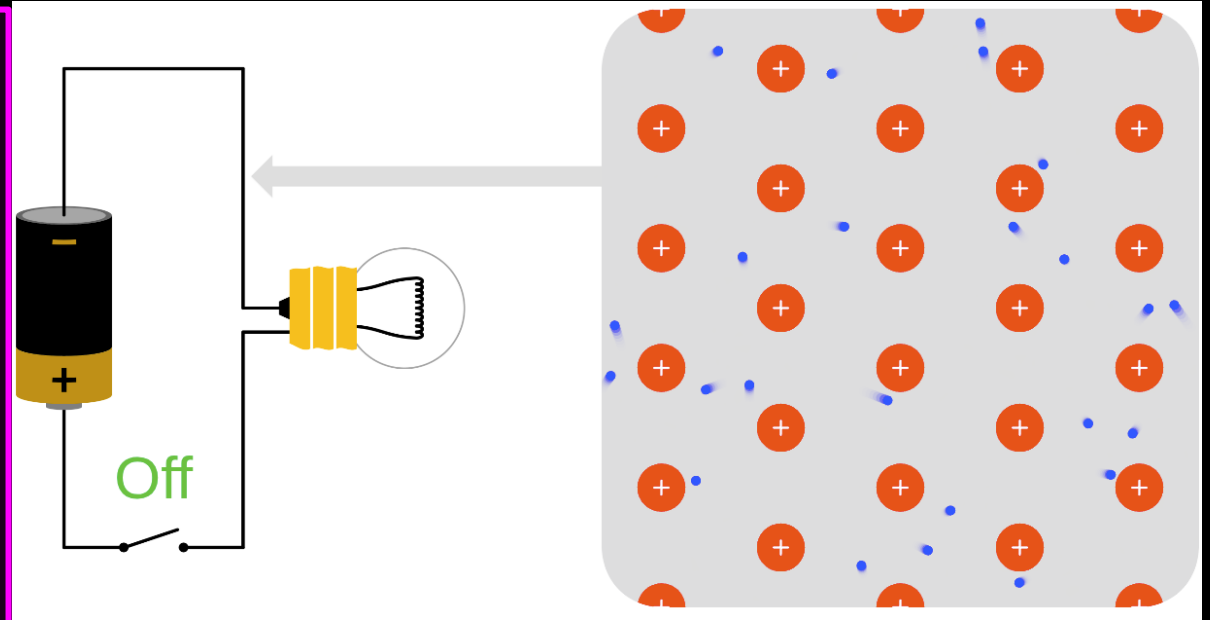
* In our discussions, we will focus only on solid conductors so that the current is carried by the negatively charged electrons in the background of fixed positive ions.

ELECTRIC CURRENTS IN CONDUCTORS

Case 1 : When no electric field is present :

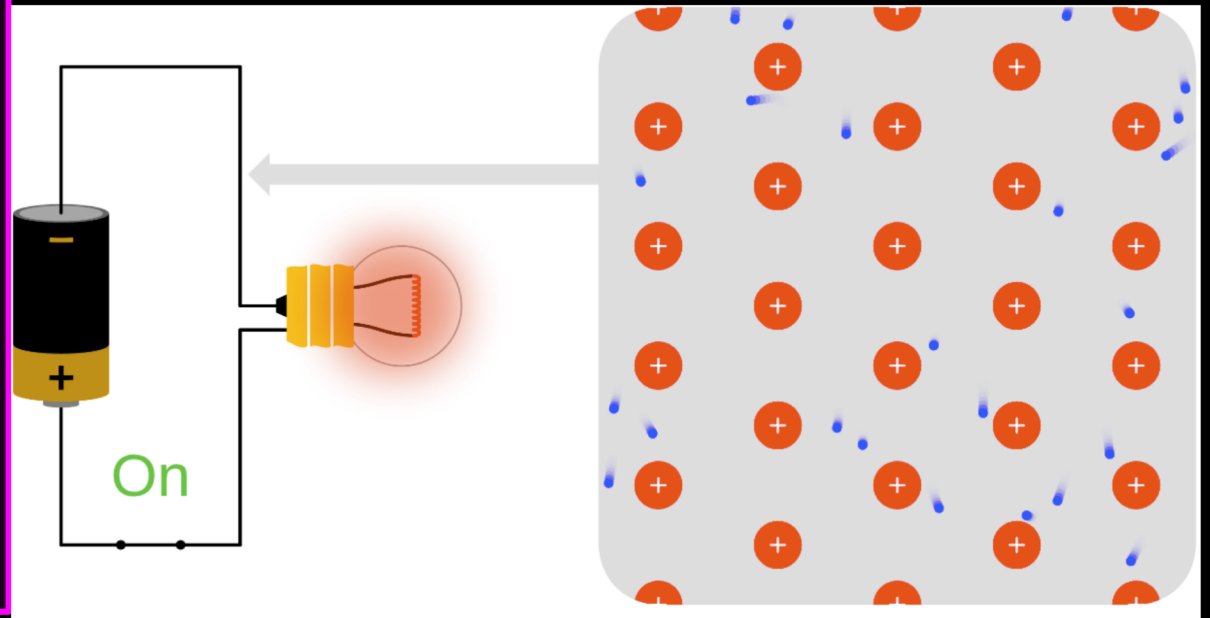
* The electrons will be moving due to thermal motion during which they collide with the fixed ions. The direction of its velocity after the collision is completely random.

Thus on the average, the number of electrons travelling in any direction will be equal to the number of electrons travelling in the opposite direction. So, there will be no net electric current.



Case 2 : When electric field is present :

* The electrons will be accelerated due to this field, in the opposite direction of the field. The electrons, as long as they are moving, will constitute an electric current.



OHM'S LAW

* A basic law regarding flow of currents was discovered by G.S. Ohm in 1828, long before the physical mechanism responsible for flow of currents was discovered.

Imagine a conductor through which a current I is flowing and let V be the potential difference between the ends of the conductor. Then Ohm's law states that the current in a conductor is directly proportional to the voltage applied:

$$V \propto I$$

or $V = RI$

* where the constant of proportionality R is called the resistance of the conductor.

The SI units of resistance is ohm (Ω)

* The resistance R not only depends on the material of the conductor but also on the dimensions (length l and cross sectional area A) of the conductor.

* In general, then resistance is proportional to length, $R \propto l$

* The resistance R is inversely proportional to the cross-sectional area, $R \propto 1/A$

$$R \propto \frac{l}{A} \text{ or } R = \rho \frac{l}{A}$$

* where the constant of proportionality called resistivity (ρ) depends on the material

CURRENT DENSITY AND EQUIVALENT FORM OF OHM'S LAW

- * **Current Density (J) :** Current per unit area (taken normal to the current), I/A , is called current density and is denoted by J . It is a vector quantity.

The SI units of the current density are A/m^2 .

$$dI = \vec{J} \cdot d\vec{A} = JdA \cos \theta$$

- * **Equivalent form of Ohm's Law :**

If E is the magnitude of uniform electric field in the conductor whose length is l , then the potential difference V across its ends is $V = El$

From Ohm's Law : $V = IR$

$$El = JAR \quad \left(\because V = El \text{ and } J = \frac{I}{A} \right)$$

$$E = \frac{RA}{l} J \quad \text{or} \quad E = \rho J \quad \left(\because \rho = \frac{RA}{l} \right)$$

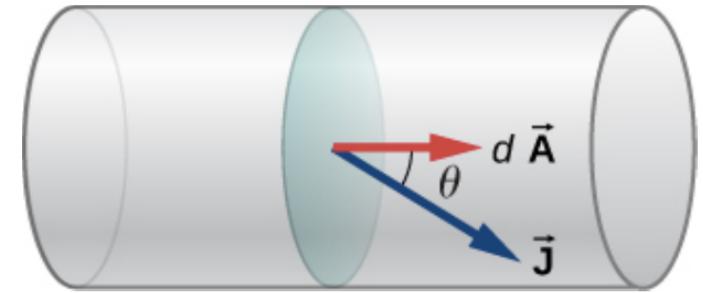


Figure 9.12 The current density $\vec{J}$ is defined as the current passing through an infinitesimal cross-sectional area divided by the area. The direction of the current density is the direction of the net flow of positive charges and the magnitude is equal to the current divided by the infinitesimal area.